■ EXCEL
Interview Questions & Answers

For Freshers — Simple English, Easy to Remember

55+ Most-Asked Excel Questions with Clear Answers + Real Examples

SECTION 1 — Excel Basics

Q1. What is Microsoft Excel and why is it used in data analytics?

Answer: Excel is a spreadsheet program by Microsoft used to store, organise, calculate, and visualise data in rows and columns. In data analytics, it's used for data cleaning, quick analysis, creating reports, pivot tables, and dashboards. It's the most widely used tool in businesses worldwide.

Q2. What is a cell, row, and column in Excel?

Answer: Cell = a single box in the spreadsheet (identified by column letter + row number, like A1, B5). Row = horizontal line of cells (Row 1, Row 2...). Column = vertical line of cells (Column A, B, C...). The intersection of a row and column = one cell.

Example: Cell B3 = column B, row 3.

Q3. What is the difference between a Workbook and a Worksheet?

Answer: Workbook = the entire Excel file (.xlsx). Worksheet (Sheet) = a single tab/page inside the workbook. One workbook can have many worksheets (like Sheet1, Sheet2, etc.).

Remember: Workbook = book. Worksheet = one page in the book.

Q4. What are the different data types in Excel?

Answer: Number — any numerical value (123, 45.6). Text/String — any text ('Hello', 'Mumbai'). Date/Time — dates and times. Boolean — TRUE or FALSE. Formula — a calculation starting with = sign. Error — like #DIV/0!, #N/A, #REF!.

Q5. What is the difference between relative, absolute, and mixed cell references?

Answer: Relative (A1) — changes when you copy formula to another cell. Absolute (A1) — never changes, always refers to that exact cell. Mixed ($A1 or A$1) — only row OR column is fixed.

Example: =B1 stays as B1 wherever you copy. =A1 becomes B1, C1 etc. when copied sideways.

Remember: Press F4 while clicking a cell reference to add $ signs.

Q6. What are keyboard shortcuts every Excel user should know?

Answer: Ctrl+C/V/X = copy/paste/cut. Ctrl+Z = undo. Ctrl+F = find. Ctrl+H = find & replace. Ctrl+Arrow = jump to last data cell. Ctrl+Shift+End = select to last used cell. Alt+= = auto sum. Ctrl+T = create table. F4 = repeat last action / toggle $ in formulas.

SECTION 2 — Lookup Formulas

Q7. What is VLOOKUP? How does it work?

Answer: VLOOKUP looks up a value in the FIRST column of a table and returns a value from another column in the same row. Syntax: =VLOOKUP(lookup_value, table_range, column_number, [exact/approximate]). Use 0 or FALSE for exact match (always use this!).

Example: =VLOOKUP(A2, ProductTable, 3, 0) — finds value in A2 in column 1 of ProductTable, returns column 3.

Remember: VLOOKUP can only look RIGHT, not left. And always use 0 for exact match!

Q8. What is INDEX-MATCH? Why is it better than VLOOKUP?

Answer: INDEX returns a value from a position. MATCH finds the position of a value. Together they work like VLOOKUP but better: can look LEFT, not affected by adding/deleting columns, faster on big data. =INDEX(return_column, MATCH(lookup_value, lookup_column, 0)).

Example: =INDEX(B2:B100, MATCH(E2, A2:A100, 0)) — finds E2 in column A, returns corresponding value from column B.

Remember: If VLOOKUP is asked — know INDEX-MATCH too. Many companies prefer INDEX-MATCH.

Q9. What is XLOOKUP? (Newer versions of Excel)

Answer: XLOOKUP is the modern replacement for VLOOKUP. It's simpler and more powerful. Syntax: =XLOOKUP(lookup_value, lookup_array, return_array, [if_not_found]). Can look left and right, handles errors built-in.

Example: =XLOOKUP(A2, Products[ID], Products[Name], 'Not Found')

Remember: XLOOKUP = VLOOKUP + INDEX-MATCH combined and simplified.

Q10. What is HLOOKUP?

Answer: HLOOKUP is like VLOOKUP but horizontal. It searches in the FIRST ROW and returns a value from a specified row below. Less commonly used than VLOOKUP.

Example: =HLOOKUP('Q3', A1:D5, 3, 0) — finds 'Q3' in row 1, returns value from row 3.

Q11. What does #N/A error mean in VLOOKUP?

Answer: #N/A means 'Not Available' — the lookup value was NOT found in the table. To handle it gracefully: wrap with IFERROR: =IFERROR(VLOOKUP(...), 'Not Found') or =IFERROR(VLOOKUP(...), 0).

Remember: Always wrap lookups with IFERROR to avoid ugly errors in reports.

SECTION 3 — Mathematical & Conditional Formulas

Q12. What is SUMIF and SUMIFS?

Answer: SUMIF adds values that meet ONE condition. SUMIFS adds values that meet MULTIPLE conditions. SUMIF syntax: =SUMIF(range, criteria, sum_range). SUMIFS: =SUMIFS(sum_range, criteria_range1, criteria1, criteria_range2, criteria2, ...).

Example: =SUMIF(C2:C100,'Electronics',D2:D100) — sum of sales where category = Electronics.

Q13. What is COUNTIF and COUNTIFS?

Answer: COUNTIF counts cells that meet ONE condition. COUNTIFS counts cells meeting MULTIPLE conditions. Very useful for frequency analysis.

Example: =COUNTIF(A2:A100,'Mumbai') — count how many times 'Mumbai' appears. =COUNTIFS(A2:A100,'Mumbai',B2:B100,'>18') — Mumbai + age>18.

Q14. What is AVERAGEIF?

Answer: AVERAGEIF calculates the average only for cells that meet a condition. Syntax: =AVERAGEIF(range, criteria, average_range).

Example: =AVERAGEIF(B2:B100,'Male',C2:C100) — average salary of male employees only.

Q15. What is the IF function?

Answer: IF checks a condition and returns one value if TRUE and another if FALSE. Syntax: =IF(condition, value_if_true, value_if_false). You can nest IFs for multiple conditions.

Example: =IF(B2>=50,'Pass','Fail') / =IF(C2>=90,'A', IF(C2>=80,'B', IF(C2>=70,'C','D')))

Q16. What is the AND and OR function?

Answer: AND returns TRUE only if ALL conditions are true. OR returns TRUE if ANY condition is true. Used inside IF to combine multiple conditions.

Example: =IF(AND(A2>50,B2='Yes'),'Eligible','Not Eligible') — both conditions must be true.

Q17. What is IFERROR?

Answer: IFERROR catches any error from a formula and replaces it with a custom value instead of showing an ugly error. Syntax: =IFERROR(formula, value_if_error).

Example: =IFERROR(VLOOKUP(A2,Table,2,0),'Not Found') — shows 'Not Found' instead of #N/A.

Remember: Always use IFERROR in reports — professional habit.

Q18. What are the TEXT functions for cleaning data?

Answer: TRIM(text) — removes extra spaces. CLEAN(text) — removes non-printable characters. UPPER/LOWER/PROPER — change case. LEFT(text,n) / RIGHT(text,n) / MID(text,start,n) — extract characters. LEN(text) — count characters. FIND/SEARCH — find position of text. SUBSTITUTE(text,old,new) — replace specific text. CONCATENATE or & — join text.

Example: =TRIM(LOWER(A2)) — remove spaces and make lowercase. =LEFT(A2,3) — first 3 characters.

Q19. What is TEXT() function?

Answer: TEXT(value, format_code) converts a number or date to text with a specific format.

Example: =TEXT(A2,'dd/mm/yyyy') — formats date. =TEXT(B2,'Rs #,##0') — formats number as currency.

Q20. What are date functions in Excel?

Answer: TODAY() — today's date. NOW() — current date+time. YEAR(date) / MONTH(date) / DAY(date) — extract parts. DATEDIF(start,end,'Y') — years between dates. EDATE(date,n) — add n months. WEEKDAY(date) — day of week (1-7). NETWORKDAYS — working days between dates.

Example: =DATEDIF(B2,TODAY(),'Y') — age in years from birthdate.

SECTION 4 — Pivot Tables

Q21. What is a Pivot Table?

Answer: A Pivot Table is a powerful tool to summarise, count, average, and analyse large data quickly WITHOUT writing any formula. You drag and drop columns to rows, columns, values, and filters areas. It instantly summarises the data.

Example: Drag 'Department' to Rows, 'Salary' to Values — instantly shows average/sum salary per department.

Remember: Pivot Table = most important Excel skill for data analysis.

Q22. How do you create a Pivot Table?

Answer: 1) Click anywhere in your data. 2) Insert → PivotTable. 3) Choose where to place it. 4) A panel appears on the right — drag fields to Rows, Columns, Values, Filters areas. 5) Click on the Value field to change Sum/Average/Count.

Q23. What is a Slicer in Excel?

Answer: A Slicer is a visual filter button connected to a Pivot Table. Click slicer buttons to filter the pivot table interactively. Example: a slicer showing years — click '2023' and the pivot table shows only 2023 data.

Example: Insert → Slicer after creating a Pivot Table.

Q24. What is 'Show Values As' in Pivot Table?

Answer: Right-click on a value in pivot → 'Show Values As' lets you show values as: % of grand total, % of row, % of column, running total, difference from previous, etc. Useful for percentage analysis.

Q25. How do you refresh a Pivot Table?

Answer: Right-click on the pivot table → Refresh. Or go to PivotTable Analyze tab → Refresh. If you add new rows to your source data, right-click → Refresh Data or change the data source.

Remember: Pivot tables don't auto-update — always refresh after data changes!

Q26. What is GETPIVOTDATA function?

Answer: When you click on a cell inside a Pivot Table to reference it in a formula, Excel automatically creates a GETPIVOTDATA formula. It fetches a specific value from a pivot table. You can use it to build dynamic reports that read from pivot tables.

SECTION 5 — Charts, Data Tools & Dashboards

Q27. What types of charts are in Excel and when to use each?

Answer: Column/Bar — compare categories. Line — show trends over time. Pie/Donut — parts of a whole (max 6 slices). Scatter — relationship between two numbers. Area — trends with emphasis on volume. Waterfall — cumulative effect (profit/loss steps). Combo — two chart types on one (column + line with secondary axis).

Q28. How do you make a chart in Excel?

Answer: 1) Select your data. 2) Insert → Charts → choose chart type. 3) Use Chart Design tab to change style, colors, layout. 4) Click on chart elements to edit title, axis labels, legend. 5) Right-click → Format to customise more.

Q29. What is Conditional Formatting?

Answer: Conditional formatting automatically changes the appearance (color, bold, icons) of cells based on their value. Home → Conditional Formatting. Use cases: Red/Yellow/Green color scale for performance, highlight cells > target, duplicate highlighting, data bars (in-cell bar chart).

Example: Highlight all sales < 1000 in red automatically.

Q30. How do you remove duplicates in Excel?

Answer: Select your data → Data tab → Remove Duplicates → choose which columns to check. Excel removes duplicate rows. Alternatively, use Conditional Formatting to highlight duplicates first to review before deleting.

Q31. What is Data Validation in Excel?

Answer: Data Validation restricts what users can enter in a cell. Data tab → Data Validation. Examples: allow only numbers between 1-100, allow only dates, create a dropdown list of options (select from a list instead of typing).

Example: Create a dropdown list of departments so users can only select valid options.

Remember: Data Validation = control what is entered = prevent bad data.

Q32. What is Text to Columns?

Answer: Text to Columns splits one column into multiple columns. Example: 'Rahul Kumar' in column A can be split into 'Rahul' in A and 'Kumar' in B. Data tab → Text to Columns → choose delimiter (space, comma, etc.).

Example: Split 'Mumbai,Maharashtra,India' into 3 separate columns.

Q33. What is the difference between SORT and FILTER in Excel?

Answer: SORT rearranges rows in ascending/descending order. Data → Sort. FILTER (Excel 365 function) returns rows that meet a condition without deleting others: =FILTER(A2:D100, B2:B100='Mumbai') — shows only Mumbai rows.

Q34. What is Power Query in Excel?

Answer: Power Query (Data → Get & Transform Data) is Excel's data cleaning tool. Import data from any source, clean it (remove columns, filter rows, split columns, merge tables, change types), and load it to your sheet. Steps are recorded and refresh automatically when data changes.

Remember: Power Query = automation for repetitive data cleaning tasks.

Q35. How do you build a basic Excel Dashboard?

Answer: 1) Raw Data on one sheet. 2) Calculations/Pivot Tables on another sheet. 3) Dashboard sheet with charts and key numbers. 4) Add slicers for interactivity. 5) Remove gridlines (View → uncheck Gridlines). 6) Use consistent colors and fonts. 7) Add titles and update dates.

Remember: Keep dashboard on one screen — no scrolling needed.

Excel Formula Quick Reference

Formula	Syntax	What it does
SUM	=SUM(A1:A10)	Add a range of numbers
AVERAGE	=AVERAGE(A1:A10)	Average of numbers
COUNT	=COUNT(A1:A10)	Count number cells
COUNTA	=COUNTA(A1:A10)	Count non-empty cells
MAX / MIN	=MAX(A1:A10)	Biggest / Smallest value
IF	=IF(A1>50,'Pass','Fail')	Conditional value
IFERROR	=IFERROR(formula,'Error')	Handle errors
VLOOKUP	=VLOOKUP(val,range,col,0)	Look up value (right only)
INDEX-MATCH	=INDEX(B:B,MATCH(val,A:A,0))	Look up value (any direction)
XLOOKUP	=XLOOKUP(val,lookup,return)	Modern lookup (365 only)
SUMIF	=SUMIF(range,criteria,sumrange)	Sum with 1 condition
SUMIFS	=SUMIFS(sumrng,rng1,crit1,...)	Sum with multiple conditions
COUNTIF	=COUNTIF(range,criteria)	Count with 1 condition
AVERAGEIF	=AVERAGEIF(range,crit,avgrng)	Average with condition
TRIM	=TRIM(A1)	Remove extra spaces
UPPER/LOWER	=UPPER(A1)	Change text case
LEFT/RIGHT/MID	=LEFT(A1,3)	Extract characters
TEXT	=TEXT(A1,'dd/mm/yyyy')	Format number/date as text
TODAY/NOW	=TODAY()	Current date/date+time
DATEDIF	=DATEDIF(A1,TODAY(),'Y')	Years/months/days between dates
CONCATENATE	=A1&' '&B1	Join text from cells
LEN	=LEN(A1)	Count characters in text

Excel is your bread and butter — practice VLOOKUP, Pivot Tables and SUMIFS daily! ■